

THE FIRST WORLD WAR

At the outbreak of World War I (1914-1918) in Europe, both sides built trenches to defend their positions. Neither the Allies (led by Britain and France) nor the Central Powers (led by Germany) could strike a decisive blow. The Battle of Messines in 1917 was a major attack by the Allies, which used underground mines planted beneath German trenches. Today, archaeologists are still finding clothing, weapons, and other evidence of the fights that raged until the Allies broke through.



Battle plans

Messines Ridge was a 264-ft- (80-m-) high hill in German-occupied Belgium, close to the border with France. The Allies planned to break through the German lines and capture the Belgian coastline.

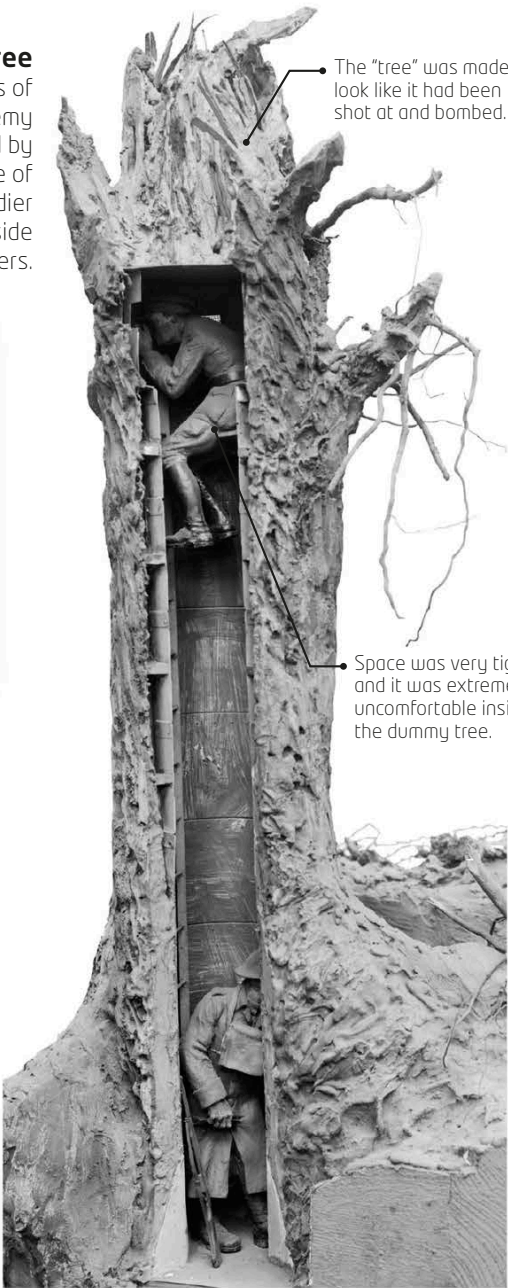
Lasting memory

Some craters from the Messines blasts still exist. The biggest, at Spanbroekmolen, was made when 90,000 lb (40,823 kg) of explosives went off. It is now called the "Pool of Peace."



Dummy tree

Allied soldiers had several ways of gathering information on the enemy including this dummy tree used by Australian troops. It was made of metal and canvas, and a soldier equipped with binoculars hid inside to spy on German soldiers.



The "tree" was made to look like it had been shot at and bombed.

Space was very tight and it was extremely uncomfortable inside the dummy tree.

Mobile weapons

The Allies used powerful cannons called howitzers to fire thousands of shells during the attack. Also called field guns, there were 108 of these smaller, wheeled howitzers at Messines and 214 larger howitzers.



Wheels allowed soldiers to move the cannon to where it was needed most on the battlefield.

